

“**My conscience** wants vegetarianism to **win over the world**. And **my subconscious** is yearning for **a piece of juicy meat**. But what **do I want?**”

The Stalker / Stalker

postapocalyptic existential drama, in which its three protagonists discuss their lives and destinies, reminiscent of Samuel Beckett's play *Waiting for Godot* (1953).

What next?

The final section deals with the Stalker's wife and child, finally closing in on his daughter's face as she lies with her head on the kitchen table, staring at three glasses that seem to rattle under her gaze while a train passes. Like many of the images in Tarkovsky's

movie, it comes with no explanation. One might see *Stalker* as a Soviet answer to Stanley Kubrick's *2001: A Space Odyssey*, which poses the question, "Where do we go from here?" But as to whether Tarkovsky was making a comment about life in the Soviet Union or life on Earth, the director himself refused to be drawn in: in his mind, a true artwork should not be reduced to its components and interpreted so simply. "We are judged not by what we did or wanted to do," he said in an

interview, "but we are judged by people who don't want to understand the work as a whole or even to look at it. Instead they isolate individual fragments and details, clutching to them and trying to prove that there is some special, main point in them. This is delirium."

To realize his stark vision, Tarkovsky searched for a suitably bleak location for *Stalker*, and found it in Estonia, at an old hydroelectric power station and a factory dumping toxic chemicals upstream. He, his wife, and actor Anatoly Solonitsyn all later succumbed to cancer, possibly due to contamination at the location. ■

After the men draw lots, the Writer is chosen to enter a metal tunnel in The Zone. The tunnel leads them toward the mysterious Room.

